

Guillermo Ochoa eyes history

Much has been said about this being a record sixth and final World Cup for Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo. But they may have to make room for one more name on that list.

Mexican goalkeeper Guillermo Ochoa has all but confirmed his participation, after which he is expected to retire.

While the final squad is yet to be announced, the 40-year-old appears set for an emotional farewell with co-host Mexico. He started in 2014, 2018 and 2022, keeping four clean sheets in 11 appearances and reaching the round of 16 in the 2014 and 2018 editions.



Richer rewards

After coming under fire for exorbitant World Cup ticket prices, FIFA has increased its already lucrative prize pool to USD 871 million, up from an initial USD 727 million.

Despite a 50 per cent rise from 2022, several FIFA members had raised concerns over tax, travel costs and preparation expenses. The increase offers some relief to the 48 participating federations, each of whom will receive an additional USD 2 million for qualifying and preparing for the tournament.

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More breathing space

Players who walk the fine line between fair and foul have been handed a lifeline, with FIFA deciding to reset yellow card counts after the group stage and the quarterfinals.

At the World Cup, players are suspended for a game if they rack up yellow cards across separate matches. In the previous edition in Qatar, the slate was wiped clean only after the quarterfinals.

With the expanded format introducing a round of 32, FIFA said the change is aimed at ensuring fewer players miss key knockout fixtures.

